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Veiled sentiments

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Safety in encounters with powerful forces, supernatural or social, is enhanced by avoiding encounters in the first place or by placing barriers between oneself and the force. The most popular protection against the evil eye, the *jinn*, and magic is an amulet, one or more pieces of paper on which a holyman has written Koranic verses or, more frequently, scribbles that people mistake for the verses. The word Awlad 'Ali use for amulet is *hjab*, meaning a protection, cover, or veil; elsewhere in the Arab world the word refers specifically to women's veils.

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Likewise, to protect oneself from more powerful people one must *tahashsham*, in the sense of acting modestly. That this involves cloaking or masking is apparent from the range of behaviors that Bedouins consider signs of modesty. First, there is dressing modestly, which for women includes veiling the face, a literal cloaking. Also masked are the "natural" needs and passions; so to *tahashsham* from someone involves neither eating nor drinking in front of him or her, nor smoking (or, in Arabic, "drinking") cigarettes. One also assumes a rigid posture and does not speak or look the superior in the eyes. These acts imply formality on the one hand and self-effacement on the other, both means of masking one's nature, of not exposing oneself to the other.

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Complete avoidance is the best protection; there is no danger of exposure if there is no interaction. Not just individuals but whole  116 categories of unequals avoid each other. Sexual segregation and, to a lesser extent, generational segregation characterize the everyday social world of the Awlad

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'Ali, and they are justified in terms of the *hasham* felt by those lower in the hierarchy. Thus, the Bedouins do not attribute the separation of the women and the young from the adult male world to the men's wish to exclude the others; rather, they understand it as the response of the weak to their discomfort in the presence of the more powerful. The response of women when adult men intrude into their world certainly attests to the validity of this interpretation. Upon a respected adult man's entrance, the only sounds are the rustlings of posture and clothing being adjusted and of wide-eyed children moving closer together, and then a hush falls on a roomful of garrulous women and boisterous children. The mood changes. Even well-born young men fall silent and seem uncomfortable in the presence of their older agnates; they do not laugh or joke but sit quietly, listening and ready to serve. Not surprisingly, they too prefer the world of their peers, of adult clients, or even of the women, their mothers, aunts, and grandmothers. By minimizing contact between those of unequal status, segregation limits the time the weak must spend feeling uncomfortable and acting with such restraint. ¹²

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12. For elaboration of these ideas on sexual segregation, see Abu-Lughod (1985a).

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